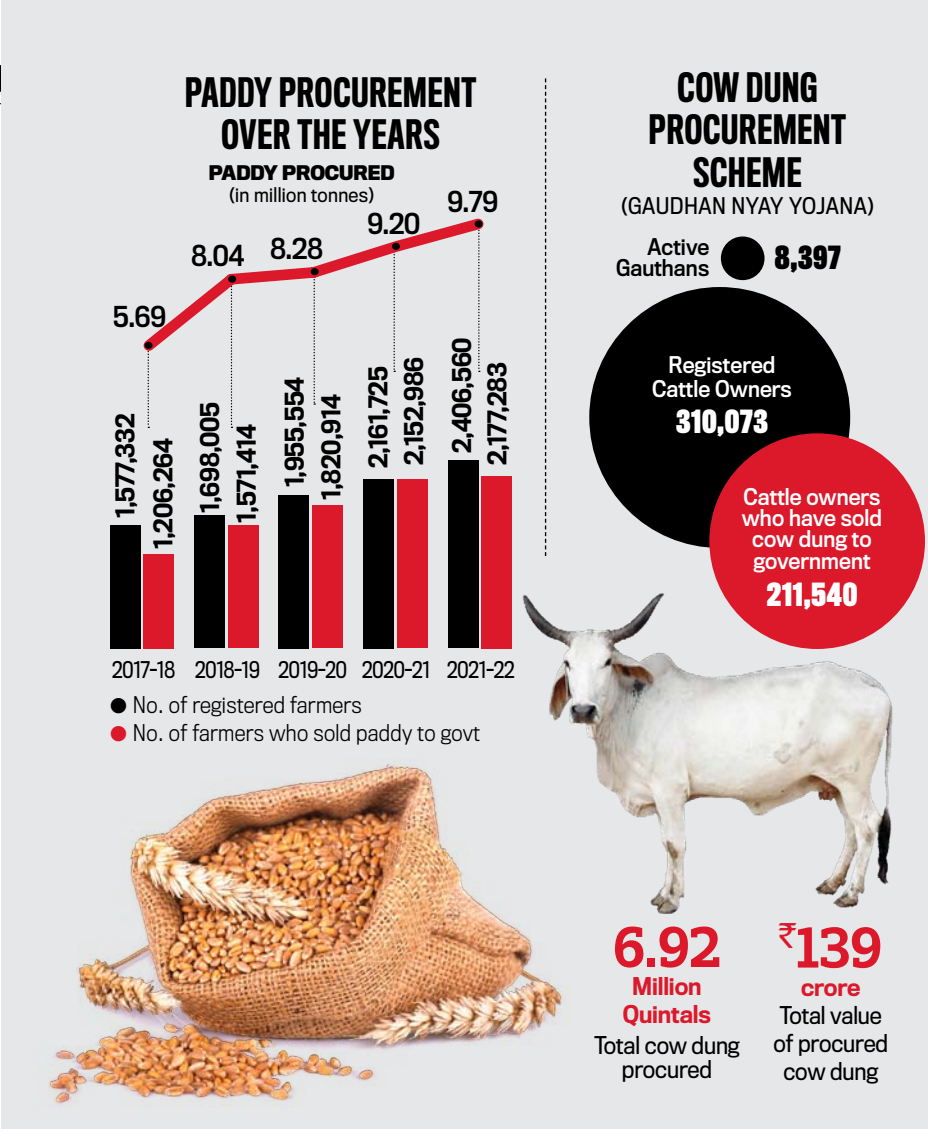


Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

CHHATTISGARH'S SCHEMES ENTAIL PUTTING MONEY IN THE HANDS OF THE BENEFICIARY, WHICH IS EXPECTED TO CONVERT INTO POLITICAL SUPPORT. IT WORKED FOR THE BJP IN THE UP POLLS

Clearly, Chhattisgarh's schemes entail putting money in the hands of the beneficiary, which is expected to translate into political support. In the recent Uttar Pradesh assembly election, this approach—seen in the PM Awas Yojana, free rations to 150 million people and the cash transfer scheme—was said to be a game-changer for the BJP. In Madhya Pradesh, the BJP government led by Shivraj Singh Chouhan is giving Rs 4,000 to every small and marginal farmer, over and above the annual Rs 6,000 given under the PM Kisan Samman Yojana.

HOW THEY PLAY OUT

"There are a total of 15 assembly seats that are fully urban, another 10 that are a mix of urban and rural and the remaining 65 seats out of the 90 in the state that are purely rural," says Rajesh Tiwari, political advisor to CM Baghel. The focus on rural schemes, therefore, is not surprising.

The population of Chhattisgarh is estimated at 27.5 million and farm /rural schemes are likely to impact 401,000 families out of the total 682,200 families in Chhattisgarh. It is estimated that the various government programmes can impact over 20 million of the state's population.

Out of the 90 assembly seats, 14 are located in the Surguja division in north Chhattisgarh, while 12 are in the southern Bastar division. Currently, the Congress holds all these seats. The bulk of seats in Chhattisgarh are located in the central plains region, largely populated by the farming community. While the rural, farm/ agriculture-oriented schemes apply equally to the predominantly tribal and forested northern and southern parts of the state, the topography and prevalent economic practices prevent them from having a big impact. To remedy this, Baghel's government has expanded the procurement of minor forest produce (MFP)—an important economic activity—from the earlier seven items to 65.

A couple of hurdles confront Baghel. While the farming community in central Chhattisgarh seems happy enough, this is also the region where OBCs dominate and from where the BJP draws the bulk of its support. He will have to find a way to win more of them over to the Congress.

Then there is the aforementioned challenge from party rival T.S. Singhdeo, who comes from the tribal north and has emerged as a champion of tribal rights through his adamant push for a strong Panchayats (Extension to Scheduled Areas), or PESA, Act, where gram sabhas will have more powers in tribal areas. Chhattisgarh is in the process of framing rules under the PESA Act. Singhdeo's clout in Ambikapur (headquarters of Surguja district) was evident, with most Congress office-bearers and leaders also skipping Baghel's Bhent Mulaqat when it covered the Lundra and Sitapur assembly seg-